

OVERVIEW

Whether it's an auditorium filled with rows facing a stage or a restaurant with cozy booths, different settings suggest, support, and impede certain behaviors. Our classrooms are no different! And while we all have some real constraints, we can think about how our choices align with our expectations for student activities. In this conversation, you'll consider how your classroom space can encourage different types of student interactions.

SPARK MEDIA & FOCUS LESSON

Animated Video

A teacher considers a variety of desk arrangements for the lesson [Big Foot Conspiracy](#).

PEDAGOGICAL THEME

Fostering Student Discourse

USING THE CONVO GUIDE FOR A GREAT ROUNDTABLE DISCUSSION

- This conversation is designed for a group of 2-5 educators over 30-60 minutes.
- The Convo Guide serves as an agenda for a roundtable conversation where everyone is there both to learn and to share their expertise.
- Each participant should have their own copy of the Convo Guide and access to the Spark Media.
- Pace yourselves to get through the entire agenda in the time you have.
- Questions aren't intended to have a single right answer; instead, they're designed to spark rich discussions.
- At the end, everyone will commit to trying "one small thing" the very next day. Consider how you might follow up with one another!

OBSERVE

5-15 MIN

- To start, take a look at the Spark Media.
- The ingredients a teacher has to work with (like class size, furniture, room construction) vary, so the implementation of the arrangements shown might look different...what are the *key features* of each arrangement?
- Imagining yourself in the shoes of a student, what does each of these physical arrangements suggest about the work you'll be doing?

DISCUSS

10-15 MIN

- How do these different arrangements support or hinder student to student discourse? What about independent student thinking?
- Even within a single class period, the way a teacher wants students to engage changes many times (e.g. going from working independently, to small groups, to whole groups, debates, etc.) When would you need physical shifts (i.e. moving desks) to support these transitions, and how do you support the transitions without physical shifts?

RELATE

10-15 MIN

- What is your vision for student discourse? What possible changes or tweaks might you make to your physical space to move towards that vision?
- What factors do you consider when you rearrange your physical classroom space?
- To prepare your students for any changes in the physical classroom space, how would you communicate and manage student expectations?

...AND COMMIT!

5-10 MIN

- What is one small thing you can do tomorrow in support of those shifts?